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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Trump's baseless claim roils visit

President's false charge of white 'genocide' makes for tense meeting with the leader of South Africa

By Gerald Imray and Aamer Madhani
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — President Donald Trump used a White House meeting to forcefully

confront South African President Cyril Ramaphosa, accusing the country of failing to address Trump's baseless claim of the systematic killing of white farmers. Trump even dimmed the lights of the Oval Office to play a video

of a far-left politician chanting a song that includes the lyrics "kill the farmer." He also leafed through news articles to underscore his point, saying the country's white farmers have faced "death, death, death, horrible death."

Trump had already cut all U.S. assistance to South Africa and welcomed several dozen white South African farmers to the U.S.

as refugees as he pressed the case that a "genocide" is underway in the country.

The U.S. president has launched a series of accusations at South Africa's Black-led government, claiming it is seizing land from white farmers, enforcing anti-white policies and pursuing an anti-American foreign policy.

Experts in South Africa say there

is no evidence of white people being targeted for their race, although farmers of all races are victims of violent home invasions in a country that suffers from a very high crime rate.

"People are fleeing South Africa for their own safety," Trump said. "Their land is being confiscated

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GENERAL ASSEMBLY

Domestic violence training bill OK'd

Legislation sparked by Brand case heads to Pritzker's desk

By Jeremy Gorner
Chicago Tribune

SPRINGFIELD — Illinois lawmakers advanced a bill that would emphasize domestic violence awareness training for members of the state's Prisoner Review Board, which came under criticism after releasing a man from state custody who then allegedly attacked a former girlfriend and fatally stabbed her young son.

The Democratic-led House passed the legislation Tuesday by a near party-line vote of 74-37 and it now heads to Gov. JB Pritzker, who a spokesperson said Wednesday intends to sign the bill into law. The bill passed in the Senate last month, with three moderate Democrats joining Republicans in voting against it: Patrick Joyce of Reddick, Meg Loughran Cappel of Shorewood and Suzy Glowiak Hilton of Western Springs.

The bill's passage came 14 months after authorities say Crosetti Brand broke into his ex-girlfriend's apartment on Chicago's North Side and attacked her before fatally stabbing her son, 11-year-old Jayden Perkins, when the boy tried to come to her rescue. The 39-year-old Brand is on trial for the attack and Jayden's family has filed a lawsuit against the review board alleging negligence in the case.

The case became a political challenge for Pritzker as the review board had been criticized a couple of years before the attack by state legislative Republicans for authorizing the early release of people convicted of killing police officers, children and committing mass murder.

In light of Jayden's case, two review board members, including the chairman, resigned. The crime also led to the

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THE WORLD'S EAR

By Angie Leventis Lourgos
Chicago Tribune

VATICAN CITY — Chicago-born Pope Leo XIV called for humanitarian aid to be allowed into war-torn Gaza, decrying the violence and suffering in the Middle East during his first general audience as pope Wednesday in St. Peter's Square.

"I renew my appeal to allow the entry of dignified humanitarian aid and to put an end to the hostilities, whose heartbreaking price is paid by the children, elderly and the sick," the first American pope declared.

At the start of the weekly event, the Holy Father crisscrossed the cobblestone square in the iconic popemobile, a white Mercedes-Benz specially constructed so the pontiff can be visible for public appearances while still protected.

A video camera captured his every facial expression, magnified on four large display screens, as he made the sign of the cross in the air and paused to bless the occasional baby. He later read a list of countries represented in the square in

Pope Leo XIV urges humanitarian aid in Gaza during first general audience



Pope Leo XIV, above, waves to the crowd, shown at top, while holding his first general audience Wednesday in St. Peter's Square at the Vatican.
BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE PHOTOS

Dolton eyes pope's youth home

Village may usurp planned auction by using eminent domain on house where the pontiff grew up. **Business**

English, ending with "the United States" and smiling as a roar rose up from the crowd.

Pope Leo XIV will hold similar general audiences almost every week for the rest of his papacy.

Friends and family members have noted the stark contrast between the 69-year-old longtime Augustinian missionary's lifestyle up until this point compared to the new life he's begun as the leader of some 1.4 billion Catholics worldwide.

The fortnight since his May 8 election has been a whirlwind of public appearances and meetings with dignitaries, including Vice President JD Vance and U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio. During Vance's audience, he presented the pontiff with a Chicago Bears jersey with No. XIV on the back and "Pope Leo" across his shoulders.

"Good choice," the pope said, looking at the gift.

The grandeur and pageantry of the position belies the simple existence the pope has led for much of his life. Born Robert Francis

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At Lurie hospital, a cap and gown

With graduation, West Leyden senior awaiting heart transplant accomplishes one of his dreams

By Carolyn Stein
Chicago Tribune

It had all the makings of a typical graduation party. Blue and yellow streamers lined the room. Signs were posted on the walls that said "Congrats Grad 2025," "You did it" and "Made the grade." In the back, there was a table full of Chips Ahoy and Oreos and even a cake that read "Congratulations Taevion" in blue frosting.

Except, the party was held on the 22nd floor of Lurie Chil-

dren's Hospital in honor of one of the hospital's patients: 18-year-old Taevion Norris. He had been attending West Leyden High School in Northlake when his senior year was suddenly interrupted in March due to heart failure, forcing him to spend the tail end of his final year of high school in the hospital.

But Norris refused to let his condition stop him from graduating on time — and succeeded. On Wednesday, Norris — wearing a blue cap and gown — was

handed his diploma. Graduation music played in the background as he traversed from one end of the hospital hallway into the room of the ceremony.

"This is a very good day. Despite what he's going through, he was still able to graduate with his class," Tainica Norris, Taevion's mother, said. "It's good that he has a big crowd to see him achieve and accomplish one of his dreams and his goals, and just to be loved by everybody, because nobody knows what it's like to face what he has."

In 2019, her eldest son was diagnosed with Duchenne muscular

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Taevion Norris, 18, a senior at West Leyden High School, is handed his diploma by District 212 Superintendent Nick Polyak, left, at Lurie Children's Hospital on Wednesday. **STACEY WESCOTT/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

TODAY'S WEATHER



High 57 Low 43

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 12

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
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